Next

By Terrance McNally

The scene opens in an examination room. Stage left there is an examination table, a scale and a cabinet filled with medical equipment. Stage right there is a desk and two chairs. The only bright color in the room is the American Flag, center stage. As the curtain rises, the room is empty.

SGT. THECH: **(Pg 61-82)** *(Off stage)* Next! *(Marion Cheever*

MARION: *(enters. He is a fat man in his late carrying a briefcase)* Hello? I'm next! Well! I think we can get this over with rather quickly.

SGT. THECH: *(busy at her desk.)* Your card and bottle, please.

MARION: *(rummaging in briefcase)* As I was starting to say, I think we can get this over with rather quickly. There's obviously been a mistake. *(laughs)* I mean I-

SGT. THECH: The government does not make mistakes. If your country has called you, it has its reasons. May I have your card and bottle, please? Is your name Marion Cheever?

MARION: Yes, it is. But you know I just had a fortieth birthday.

SGT. THECH: They're taking older men -- inching up all the time. Remove all articles of clothing including your shoes and socks.

MARION: Who are you?

SGT. THECH: Your examining officer, Sgt. Thech. And by the authority vested in me by this government, I order you to strip.

INTRODUCTION

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MARION: A lady examining officer! Oh that's funny! They must be pretty hard up these days.

SGT. THECH: And if you have not begun to strip in the next ten seconds I will complete these forms without further examination and report you to the board of examiners as fit for duty.

MARION: *(as if coming out of a trance)* Oh my God, I'm sorry. I don't know what I was thinking. What did you say?

SGT. THECH: You have ten seconds. *(timing him)* 1, one thousand; 2, one-thousand *(Marion strips)*

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SGT. THECH: Age.

MARION: Forty . . . eight! I'm forty-eight years old.

SGT. THECH: Your occupation, Mr. Cheever.

MARION: I'm a dancer.

SGT. THECH: Toe or tap.

MARION: Oh really! Toe or tap! I'm the assistant manager of the Fine Arts Theatre, 58th Street and Park Avenue. You've probably heard of us. Toe or tap! I was funning!

SGT. THECH: Rheumatic fever.

MARION: *(blinking hard)* Unh! Did I have rheumatic fever? No, no I don't think so.

SGT. THECH: Mumps.

MARION: *(jumping at this)* Yes! Yes, yes, yes! I was in bed for months -- practically had last rites!

SGT. THECH: Venereal disease.

MARION: Not yet! I wish you'd let me tell you about my mumps!

SGT. THECH: Do you drink.

MARION: Whenever I smoke. Smoking makes me drink and drinking makes me smoke. It's a vicious circle.

SGT. THECH: All right, Mr. Cheever, on the scale now, please. *(turns and sees him draped in the flag)* Drop that flag.

MARION: I was just admiring it! I have one just like it at home. *(Sgt. Thech returns the flag to its proper place. Marion walks along, unwilling to give up its protection)* Could I have a little robe or something? *(Sgt. Thech hands him a sheet)* Thank you. Thank you.

SGT. THECH: On the scale.

MARION: *(wrapping the sheet around himself)* I'll refuse to go, you know. You're just wasting your time. *(under his breath)* I hate this whole day! It's humiliating, that's what it is. Calling a man in here and . . .

SGT. THECH: *(listening to his chest with a stethoscope)* Breath. In, out. In, out.

MARION: *(Marion is very ticklish)* Don't do that! *(laughs)*

SGT. THECH: Unh-hunh!

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MARION: What did that mean? "Unh-hunh?" You heard something you didn't like?

SGT. THECH: Open. *(sticks a tongue depressor down his throat and checks his eyes and ears with a light)*

MARION: I hate this. I hate it a lot. *(beat)* When you were examining my heart, did you hear something I should know about? It wasn't very subtle, going "unh-hunh" like that. It's my ticker, so if there's anything wrong I'd like to know about it. *(Sgt. Thecb crosses the room, turns to face him and speaks very softly. We just see her lips moving)* What? What did you say?

SGT. THECH: Your hearing is perfect.

MARION: Now just a minute. I will not be railroaded.

SGT. THECH: *(holding up an eye chart)* Read this chart -- third line.

MARION: *(running all the letters together)* TOZDY!

SGT. THECH: The second line.

MARION: The second line's a little fuzzy.

SGT. THECH: Try the top line. Mr. Cheever.

MARION: *(with much squinting)* The top line's a real problem. Let's see -- it's a . . . Z!

SGT. THECH: Excellent.

MARION: Now just a minute. It's an E. I said it was a Z. I failed that test. You give me credit for failing!

SGT. THECH: Failure is relative in any case, private.

MARION: Private? You've got me inducted when I haven't even been given a full opportunity to fail yet?

SGT. THECH: This is your opportunity, Mr. Cheever, don't pass it up. *(takes his blood pressure)*

MARION: I've heard of shanghaiing but this little episode is out and out kidnapping. I simply won't go. You can't just take a man out of civilian life and plop him into the army. So there's a war on, I didn't start it. I'm on the verge of my big break. I've stood in the back of that lousy theatre for eleven years and they are going to promote me next winter. I am going to be the manager, thank you. Unh-hunh, sergeant, I'm **not** going into any army, war or peace!

SGT. THECH: *(makes ready to take a blood sample)* Close your eyes and count to ten slowly and

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then touch the tip of your nose with your left index finger.

MARION: Oh, all right, that sounds easy. One, two, three, four . . . five, six *(suddenly panicked)* Wait! Wait, wait, wait! I saw it. *(Sgt. Thech is holding a syringe)* I hate needles. I'm not afraid of them, I just don't like them. *(Sgt. Thech draws blood)* Oh my God! I'm going to have a heart attack. *(Sgt. Thech finishes)* I'm bleeding. Look at this, I'm bleeding.

SGT. THECH: All right, Mr. Cheever, you can get dressed now. Your physical examination is over.

MARION: Oh. It's over? Well, that wasn't so bad. How did I do? Am I 4-F?

SGT. THECH: I found no evidence of physical abnormality.

MARION: *(aghast)* You found no evidence of physical abnormality? Now wait a minute. What about my blood pressure? I want more testing. I'm not leaving until I get a better verdict. What about my sinus condition? Did you know I had one? Of course not, you didn't look up my nose. What kind of examination is it without looking up a person's nose? A lot of things could be wrong up there. I can't breathe seven months out of the year. Write that down. And what about my eye test? I know I failed my eye test!

SGT. THECH: *(busy at her desk)* If you won't cooperate, I judge you on the basis of objective evidence. You do not squint, you're not wearing glasses and you saw my lips moving at fifteen feet away. You'd have to be a lot smarter and better rehearsed than you are to fool an examining officer.

MARION: *(triumphant)* Then what about my feet? You didn't even make me take my socks off. *(takes off socks)* Here. Now look at this. They're flat. See how flat they are? Do you see any arch? And see, see all those corns? I was born with all these corns. Ask yourself, is that normal? *(Sgt. Thech continues working at desk) (shows her his teeth)* And my teeth! They're full of decay. My gums are very spongy. *(desperately)* And you haven't asked me one single question about my mind. For all you know I could be a raving lunatic.

SGT. THECH: *(shrugs and administers the psychological/intelligence tests)* I have twelve apples.

MARION: *(thrown)* You have what?

SGT. THECH: You have twelve apples. Together we have . . .

MARION: *(involuntarily)* Twenty-four apples. *(realizes what he's done and groans)*

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SGT. THECH: Who was the first President of the United States?

MARION: George Washington. Was that right?

SGT. THECH: Who were the allies of the United States in the Second World War?

MARION: The good people.

SGT. THECH: Who were its enemies?

MARION: No one. We had no enemies.

SGT. THECH: Who are the allies of the United States now?

MARION: Just about everyone.

SGT. THECH: Who are its enemies?

MARION: Who can tell?

SGT. THECH: Name three of the twelve Apostles.

MARION: Joseph, his brother and his sister!

SGT. THECH: If you were seated in a theatre and saw a fire break out before the rest of the audience noticed it -- what would you do?

MARION: As a theatre manager I know this. The main thing is I wouldn't want to start a panic. So I'd very quietly leave and go home.

SGT. THECH: What is the similarity between a chair and a couch?

MARION: A chair and a couch? You can sit on them.

SGT. THECH: A rabbit and a squirrel.

MARION: *(reasonably)* You could sit on a rabbit and a squirrel. The rabbit might even like it.

SGT. THECH: Have you ever suffered from night terrors? Insomnia?

MARION: Of course, insomnia! Because of the night terrors.

SGT. THECH: Have you ever indulged in homosexual activities.

MARION: They have been very good to me.

SGT. THECH: When did you stop?

MARION: Who said anything about stopping?

SGT. THECH: Did you have a normal relationship with your father?

MARION: After we stopped dating the same girl, everything was fine.

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SGT. THECH: Do you have any history of bedwetting?

MARION: Even my top sheet is rubber.

SGT. THECH: *(abruptly)* All right, Mr. Cheever, the examination is over.

MARION: Well? How did I do? Am I 4-F yet?

SGT. THECH: You'll get your classification in the mail. I don't think you have anything to worry about. I doubt if they would find someone like you acceptable. You may go now. I'm through with you. *(turns her back to him and begins typing up his test results)*

MARION: *(dressing)* Now you're through with me and would like me to go. You have taken my time, you have taken my blood, you have taken my urine, you have taken my secrets and now you would like me out of here? Well I'm not going. If I go I take ***all*** of me. I'd like my blood and my urine back! I mean I'm 4-F -- you can't have any use for them. *(Sgt. Tbecb types*) I demand an apology! I have given everything to everyone and now I want something back!

You know what the ushers at the theatre call me behind my back? Fatso. Yeah! Because that is exactly what I am. A fatso. *(bangs on Sgt. Thech's desk with his fist)* How dare you call me in here, examine me, ignore me, dismiss me and tell me I'm not acceptable. **You** are not acceptable! Stop it! And listen to me! I said stop! *(puts his hands over the typewriter keys)* Good. Very good! *(describes everything Sgt. Thech does while she is doing it-- as if he were giving her the orders)* That's right. Fold the paper. Open the drawer. Put it away. Close it. Now you're doing exactly what you're told. Get up. Fold the sheet. Check the instruments. Excellent. Now out you go. Close the door. There! *(Sgt. Tbecb has left the room, closing the door behind her)*

SGT. THECH: NEXT!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Terrence McNally
Book: Terrence McNally 15 Short Plays, Pgs 61-82
ISBN: 978-1880399347
Publisher: Smith and Kraus Pub Inc
Date (Month/Year): June 1994

AWARD HISTORY

2016 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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